



CONVENTION ON MIGRATORY SPECIES

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MEMORANDUM OF UNDERSTANDING CONCERNING
CONSERVATION, RESTORATION AND SUSTAINABLE
USE OF THE SAIGA ANTELOPE
Astana, Kazakhstan, 12 – 14 March 2025

OVERVIEW REPORT ON SAIGA CONSERVATION STATUS AND SAIGA MOU IMPLEMENTATION

*(prepared by the Association for the Conservation of Biodiversity of Kazakhstan (ACBK) on
behalf of the CMS Secretariat)*

Summary:

The document provides an overview of the information provided in national and project reports submitted to the CMS Secretariat in accordance with Paragraph 6 of the Saiga MOU as well as additional information available to the ACBK.

The document was revised to correct a typo in paragraph 4.

Action requested:

- Review and endorse the report.

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Table of Abbreviations

ACBK	–	Association for the Conservation of Biodiversity of Kazakhstan
ADCI	–	Altyn Dala Conservation Initiative
CITES	–	Convention on International Trade in Endangered Species of Wild Fauna and Flora
CMS	–	Convention on the Conservation of Migratory Species of Wild Animals
FFI	–	Fauna & Flora
FZS	–	Frankfurt Zoological Society
FWC	–	Forestry and Wildlife Committee of the Ministry of Ecology and Natural Resources of Kazakhstan.
IUCN	–	International Union for the Conservation of Nature
KZ	–	Kazakhstan
MIA	–	Ministry of Internal Affairs
MN	–	Mongolia
MOS	–	Meeting of the Signatories
MOU	–	Memorandum of Understanding
NABU	–	Naturschutzbund Deutschland
NGO	–	Non-governmental organisation
RSPB	–	Royal Society for the Protection of Birds
RU	–	Russian Federation
SCA	–	Saiga Conservation Alliance
TCM	–	Traditional Chinese Medicine
USFWS	–	United States Fish and Wildlife Service
UZ	–	Uzbekistan
WCS	–	Wildlife Conservation Society
WWF	–	World-wide Fund for Nature

1. Introduction

- 1 Pursuant to paragraph 6 of the Memorandum of Understanding concerning Conservation, Restoration and Sustainable Use of the Saiga Antelope (Saiga MOU), the Secretariat shall prepare an Overview Report compiled on the basis of information at its disposal pertaining to the Saiga Antelope (*Saiga spp.*). This report was prepared by the Association for the Conservation of Biodiversity of Kazakhstan (ACBK) with input from other organisations on behalf of the CMS Secretariat. Funding for the preparation of this report was provided by the United States Fish and Wildlife Service (USFWS) was put on hold following the change in the US administration.
- 2 National Reports by the Signatories are the primary source of information for the Overview Report. The Secretariat provided the national reporting templates to all MOU Signatories, and the project reporting templates to all Cooperating Organisations, which had signed the MOU, and to other organisations concerned with Saiga conservation. Further information was gathered through a review of relevant peer-reviewed publications and UN reports (such as those prepared by the Secretariats of CMS and of the Convention on International Trade in Endangered Species of Wild Fauna and Flora CITES). Additional information available to ACBK was also used, which consists mostly of articles published in Saiga News, which is a key mechanism for information exchange for coordinating actions under the Saiga MOU.
- 3 All Range States have submitted reports for MOS5 under the Saiga MOU, detailing the enormous amount of work which has been undertaken to implement the MTIWP 2021-2025. Details about activities in various fields of Saiga conservation, management and research can be found in this document and in the National Reports, which are available on the website of the Saiga MOU.
- 4 In line with the Saiga MOU, the CMS Secretariat invited Signatories and Cooperating Organisations to provide information on the measures and activities undertaken to implement the Medium-Term International Work Programme for the Saiga Antelope (2021-2025). As of 13 February four Signatory States (Kazakhstan, Mongolia, Russian Federation and Uzbekistan,) and seven Cooperating Organisations submitted official reports to the CMS Secretariat.
- 5 This report does not provide all information contained in the National and Project Reports. It only summarises the information most relevant for reviewing the MTIWP implementation contained in these reports to allow an overall assessment of the implementation progress of measures agreed in the MTIWP 2021-2025. It also does not repeat information reported in previous Overview Reports concerning activities carried out and conservation issues occurring in previous reporting periods. Previous Overview Reports can be found at the CMS's [Saiga MOU website](#).
- 6 As the template for National and Project Reports is not aligned with the structure of the MTIWP, it has not been possible to fully assess its implementation in this Overview Report. For the future it would be beneficial to change the template and follow the work programme structure, which would make the reporting on implementation progress easier.

2. Conservation status and trend

- 7 While the IUCN recognizes two Saiga subspecies, namely the nominate subspecies *Saiga tatarica tatarica* found in most Range States and *Saiga tatarica mongolica* endemic to western Mongolia, CMS and CITES consider them to be two separate species, *Saiga tatarica* and *Saiga borealis*, following the taxonomy of Wilson & Reeder (3rd edition, Mammal Species of the World). This report treats the different Saiga therefore as two separate species following the CMS nomenclature.
- 8 Globally, Saiga Antelopes occur in 5 large populations (Figure 1). Four of them belong to the *S. tatarica* species and have the following names based on geographic areas they occur in: Ustyurt (Kazakhstan, Uzbekistan, and historically Turkmenistan), Betpak-Dala (Kazakhstan, Russian Federation), Ural (Kazakhstan, Russian Federation), and Northwest Pre-Caspian (Russian Federation). There is only one population of *S. borealis*, located in Mongolia.

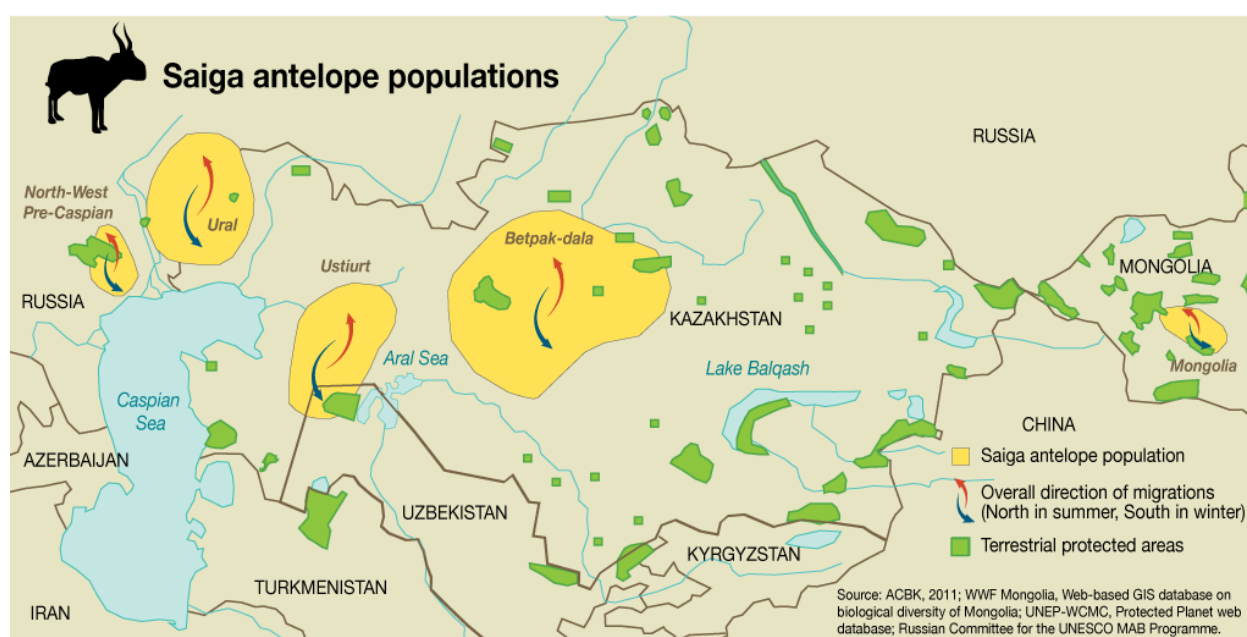


Figure 1. Global distribution of Saiga Antelope populations.

- 9 National Reports indicate most recent population sizes for each country as follows: more than 2.8 million animals in Kazakhstan and increasing; about 500 Saiga in Uzbekistan with an unclear trend; about 40,000 animals in the Russian Federation and increasing, 15,540 Saiga and increasing in Mongolia (Table 1). These figures have to be treated with caution, as they change with season due to transboundary movements of Saiga in some of the populations. No Saiga have been observed in Turkmenistan for many years. The best available estimate of the global Saiga population size is currently about 2.9 million. This is the largest ever recorded population size since the start of population surveys in the 1950s.

Table 1: Saiga population sizes based on National Reports of Saiga Range States to the CMS Secretariat for Saiga MOS5, compared with the same information from the previous four meetings. The figures are not directly comparable between years and populations because of variations in survey effort, time, and methodology.

Population	2006	2010	2015	2020	2024	Trend in 2024
Ustyurt [KZ, UZ] ¹	17,800	4,900	1270	5900	63,600 ³	Increasing
Betpak-Dala [KZ, RU] ¹	18,300	53,440	31,300	111,500	1,150,000 ³	Increasing
Ural [KZ, RU] ¹	12,900	27,140 ²	51,700	217,000	1,620,000 ³	Increasing
Mongolia [MN]	3,169	8,016±1656	14,869 ⁴	5,070	15,540 ⁵	Increasing
NW Pre-Caspian [RU]	15,000-20,000	10,000-20,000	4,500-5,000	8,500	40,000	Increasing
TOTAL	67,169-72,169	103,496-113,496	103,639-104,139	348,120	2,889,440 ⁶	Increasing

¹ Numbers from Kazakhstan aerial survey (does not include resident populations in other countries [UZ particularly] or those outside survey area).

² 39,060 estimated in April 2010, 11,920 estimated died in disease outbreak May 2010

³ 2019 spring estimate (no surveys in 2020 due to Corona pandemic)

⁴ 2014 estimate based on a ground survey

⁵ January 2020 estimate

⁶ Assuming 300 resident individuals in Uzbekistan

- 10 However, mass mortality events, which were observed in the recent past in the Ural population (estimated 12,000 Saiga died in 2010), to a greater extent in the Betpak-Dala population (estimated >200,000 Saiga died in 2015) and in the Mongolian species (estimated >5,000 Saiga died in winter 2016/17), illustrate that even large Saiga populations can be rapidly decimated by such catastrophic events. Saiga Antelope populations should therefore be large enough to withstand such catastrophes and be able to recover swiftly after population collapses, which can be caused not only by diseases, but also by harsh climatic conditions like dzhuts in winter or droughts in summer, barriers to migration due to new infrastructure, or intensive poaching.
- 11 Almost all populations show an increasing trend since the previous Meeting of Signatories to the Saiga MOU (Saiga MOS4) held in 2021, but the rate of growth differs considerably between populations. The populations in Kazakhstan grow at highest rates and have recovered quickly from previous catastrophes. The Ural population exceeds by far the largest ever recorded population size of 298,000 animals, recorded in 1992 and has reached more than five times the size in 2024. Populations in the Russian Federation and Mongolia are also growing, but at a much slower pace. After the mass mortality in 2016/2017, the Mongolian Saiga has in the meanwhile recovered to levels, which had been reported for 2015. In Uzbekistan, however, the trend is difficult to determine due to the low number of animals.
- 12 The IUCN Species Survival Commission's Antelope Specialist Group re-assessed the Saiga Antelope for the IUCN Red List of Threatened Species in December 2023. The species is now classified as Near Threatened under criteria A4bde. Due to extreme data uncertainty an assessment as Endangered, Vulnerable, or Least Concern are equally plausible, as stated in the assessment.
- 13 The Saiga Antelope has been one of the first species to be assessed under the IUCN's Green Status of Species initiative, which estimates how close a species is to being fully recovered and to understand the influence of conservation action on species recovery. The Species Recovery Score in the recent assessment from 2024 has increased to 48% from 38% in 2021. Though it is still classified as Largely Depleted, it is near the threshold for Moderately Depleted. The status of Saiga is assessed as being highly dependent on conservation actions. Past conservation action has prevented the species from becoming extinct in some parts of the range. This dependence on conservation actions is likely to continue in the future.
- 14 Unlike in the previous Overview Report prepared for Saiga MOS4 in 2021, major threats differ among Range States. Climate is still rated important by most Range States, whereas illegal hunting has become less threatening for the species except in Kazakhstan. An important threat mainly mentioned by Mongolia and Uzbekistan are barriers to migration. A specific threat for the Mongolian Saiga population rated very high is habitat degradation, which has not been mentioned by any other Range State. Another very high threat in Mongolia is livestock competition, which also has become increasingly important in Kazakhstan. The Pre-Caspian Saiga population in the Russian Federation suffers from habitat loss, which is indicated as a high threat in the National Report.

- 15 The National Reports of Saiga MOU Signatory States list the main threats listed in table 2.

Table 2: Main threats to Saiga populations per country (Kazakhstan – KZ, Mongolia – MN, Russian Federation – RU, Uzbekistan – UZ).

	Nil	Low	Medium	High	Very high	Unknown
hunting for meat (illegal hunting)	MN	RU, UZ	KZ			
hunting for horns/trade (illegal hunting)		MN, UZ	RU	KZ		
Habitat loss			KZ, MN, UZ	RU		
Livestock competition		UZ	RU	KZ	MN	
Disease		RU	KZ, MN			UZ
Climate		KZ		MN, RU, UZ		
Predation		KZ, MN	RU, UZ			
Fragmentation		KZ	MN, RU			
Demographic factors		MN, RU	KZ, UZ			
Barriers to migration			KZ, RU	MN	UZ	
Habitat degradation / overgrazing					MN	

3. Legal Status of the species

- 16 At the international level, the Saiga Antelope (both *Saiga tatarica* and *Saiga borealis*) is listed on Appendix II of CMS. The relevant CMS instrument is the Saiga MOU, which has been in force since 2006. Saiga is also one of the target species of the Central Asian Mammals Initiative (Resolution 11.24 (Rev.COP13)). Both Saiga species are listed on Appendix II of CITES with the annotation of “a zero export quota for wild specimens traded for commercial purposes”.
- 17 In **Kazakhstan**, the Saiga is considered a game species with special regulations applying to it. There is currently no defined hunting period and no hunting permits are being issued. A moratorium on Saiga hunting, which has been in force since 1998, has ended at the end of 2023. Illegal hunting of Saiga or illegal trade in its products are subject to high fines, imprisonment, and confiscations.
- 18 In **Mongolia**, Saiga is classified as 'Very Rare' and is protected by the Law on Fauna. This classification provides legal protection, prohibiting hunting, trade, and any activities that could harm the species or its habitat. The species is listed as 'Endangered' in the national red list assessment. Hunting of Saiga has been illegal in Mongolia since the 1930s. Mongolian legislation strictly prohibits the hunting, possession, and domestic trade of Saiga and its parts under the Law on Fauna. Violations, including illegal trade, are subject to severe penalties such as fines, imprisonment, and confiscation. Take is allowed only for scientific and educational purposes, but these require special permits. Enforcement is carried out by environmental inspectors, law enforcement, and customs officials, with public awareness campaigns supporting compliance.
- 19 In the **Russian Federation**, the Saiga Antelope is listed in the national Red Book as species threatened by extinction since 2021. It is also included in the regional Red Books of the Republic of Kalmykia (2013), Astrakhan (2014), Orenburg (2019), Volgograd (2017), and Rostov (2014) regions. Hunting Saiga had been prohibited since 1999 until 2020 at the regional level, since then at the federal level. As long as the species is listed in the Red Book of the Russian Federation, hunting will not be possible in the country. Trade in Saiga parts and derivatives is forbidden and since 2013 included in the criminal code of the Russian Federation. Serious fines or imprisonment are foreseen by the law in case of violations of the hunting or trade ban.
- 20 In **Uzbekistan**, Saiga has the status 1 CR - a species on the brink of extinction (Red Book of Uzbekistan, 2019). Hunting Saiga as well as trade in its products are prohibited. Violations are subject to high fines.

4. Review of the implementation of the MTIWP 2021-2025

1.0 Implementation

1.1 Ensure that all Saiga populations and the Range States have appropriate resources to implement the MOU.

- 21 This has not been fully achieved. Each country has some limited financial and human resources for Saiga conservation and research but it doesn't match the requirements for full implementation of the MoU and the Medium-Term International Work Programme.

1.3 Encourage the Saiga research and conservation community to regularly exchange project information and progress reports through the e-bulletin Saiga News and the online Saiga Resource Centre, facilitated by the organizations implementing the technical coordination of the CMS MOU.

- 22 The newsletter "Saiga News" continues to be published by the Saiga Conservation Alliance (SCA) in six languages (English, Russian, Kazakh, Chinese, Uzbek, Mongolian) making it a major forum for information exchange on Saiga conservation and research. It is the leading source of Saiga related research and conservation updates from the different Range States and beyond and therefore a crucial tool for information sharing among conservationists and decision makers, fostering a global Saiga conservation community. Since Saiga MOS4 in 2021, four new issues have been published.

- 23 SCA also hosts and manages the Saiga Resource Centre, an online platform in 4 languages (Chinese, English, Kazakh, Russian) serving as a growing repository of information about the Saiga Antelope and its conservation. The online resources are publicly accessible and include scientific papers, theses and reports, all 29 issues of Saiga News, educational material, videos and images.

1.5 Clarify phylogenetic relationships in the genus Saiga to inform the implementation of international conventions and facilitate appropriate action.

- 24 Rey-Iglesia et. al. (2022) genetically characterized the Mongolian Saiga subspecies using both mitochondrial [control region (CR)] and nuclear markers (19 microsatellites). Results demonstrate that the Mongolian Saiga presents low mitochondrial diversity - similar levels of genetic diversity were obtained in previous studies based on smaller fragments of the mtDNA control region. None of the haplotypes identified in Mongolian Saiga were detected in the populations from Kazakhstan (Betpak-Dala) or Russia (Kalmykia), suggesting isolation of the two subspecies at the mitochondrial level. However, conclusions should be treated with caution as sample sizes were relatively small. [6]

- 25 The Russian Federation reported that the All-Russian Scientific Research Institute "Ecology" holds a collection of 278 pairs of Saiga horns obtained from the Chernye Zemli Reserve. These samples were intended for studies aimed at identifying potential genetic diversity among Saiga populations. However, no information regarding the results of these studies has been provided for the reporting period.

1.6 Develop national Saiga conservation Action Plans, align them with NBSAPs and share them with others through the CMS Secretariat and the Saiga Resource Centre.

- 26 **Kazakhstan** currently doesn't have a specific Saiga conservation action plan and is in the process of updating its National Biodiversity Strategy and Action Plan under the

Convention on Biological Diversity. Activities on Saiga are included in this document under the section on “Improvement of the system of monitoring, protection and sustainable use of wildlife”. Specific activities for Saiga include expansion of the Saiga remote sensing program; management of Saiga populations on a scientific basis, maintaining populations at sustainably high numbers, taking into account the capacity of the range, the interests of agriculture, and obtaining Saiga derivatives, establishing a system for tagging Saiga derivatives and tracking their movements, and exporting possibilities of selling Saiga products (horns, skins, etc.).

- 27 **Mongolia** developed a national conservation strategy for Saiga in 2021, but the endorsement of the Ministry of Environment and Climate Change is still pending.
- 28 The Strategy for the Conservation of Rare and Threatened Species of Animals, Plants and Fungi of the **Russian Federation** 2030 was approved by the Government in 2014. In 2021 the Russian Federation adopted the Strategy for the Conservation of Saiga in the Russian Federation, which seeks, through effective management and captive breeding, to ensure the protection of the three populations occurring in Russia.
- 29 In **Uzbekistan**, topics on Saiga conservation are included in two governmental decrees: “On approval of the strategy for the conservation of biological diversity in the Republic of Uzbekistan for the period 2019 - 2028” (dated 11.06.2019) and “On approval of the concept of environmental protection of the Republic of Uzbekistan until 2030” (dated 30.10.2019).

1.10 Encourage all Saiga antelope Range and consumer States to join CITES and CMS.

- 30 The CMS Secretariat regularly conducts information sessions about the benefits and costs of accession to CMS for Range States of CMS-listed species, which are not yet Parties to the Convention. Turkmenistan has become a Party to CMS in 2021 and a Party to CITES in 2024.

1.11 Coordinate conservation efforts and promote cooperation between all stakeholders in the Saiga range.

- 31 SCA and ACBK, in close collaboration with the CMS Secretariat, have continued to provide technical support to the MOU throughout this reporting period and have achieved ongoing success in fostering international cooperation through supporting information exchange, research collaborations, strategy development, outreach and education activities.

1.12 Encourage Range States, China and other consumer countries, to conclude and implement bilateral cooperative agreements on matters of mutual interest to support the MOU's implementation.

- 32 In 2021, the Ministry of Ecology, Geology and Natural Resources of Kazakhstan and the Ministry of Natural Resources and Ecology of the Russian Federation signed an agreement on the conservation, restoration and use of transboundary Saiga populations. The goals of this agreement are e.g. to coordinate protection measures on both sides of the border, exchange data about Saiga distribution and migration and coordinate mitigation measures for any border fence issues. Kazakhstan and Uzbekistan signed a similar agreement in 2010, and in February 2024 at CMS COP 14 a memorandum for cooperation on the conservation of wildlife on the Ustyurt Plateau was signed by Kazakhstan, Uzbekistan and later also Turkmenistan.

2.0 Anti-poaching

2.2 Strengthen anti-poaching units and where needed establish more, for the protection of all Saiga populations in all Range States, including where appropriate complementing state anti-poaching units with voluntary rangers from local communities.

- 33 In 2022, the Government of Kazakhstan established the “Bokey Orda” State Nature Reserve within the range of the Ural Saiga population, employing 54 rangers. The Altyn Dala Conservation Initiative supported the operationalization of this reserve by providing protected area staff with equipment and training in areas such as SMART (Spatial Monitoring and Reporting Tool), monitoring, data collection, and storage. The project aimed to enable the adoption of best practices for effective, evidence-based patrolling, with the goal of reducing Saiga poaching through the efficient collection, analysis, and use of ranger patrol data to inform management decisions for Saiga conservation.
- 34 Additionally, **an exchange visit to Tanzania** was organized in 2022 for representatives from the Ministry of Ecology, Geology and Natural Resources of the Republic of Kazakhstan (including the Vice Minister), the Committee for Forestry and Wildlife (Vice Chairman), and two members from Okhotzooptom and ACBK. The visit provided an opportunity to learn about anti-poaching strategies in the Serengeti National Park. Participants gained valuable insights into human-wildlife conflict resolution, the use of technology for anti-poaching efforts, and the establishment of control centers for ranger unit management.
- 35 The ACBK’s Ustyurt Monitoring Team (UMT) conducts year-round patrols across the Ustyurt range. In collaboration with government agencies, including Okhotzooptom, the police, and regional forestry and wildlife rangers, the UMT carries out anti-poaching patrols, wildlife monitoring, vehicle inspections, resident outreach, and awareness-raising activities.

2.3 Enable protocols and agreements between relevant Range States to be applied at the operational level, by supporting and facilitating **transboundary exchange and communication between enforcement officers and rangers** to strengthen protection of Saigas across shared borders.

- 36 According to the information available to the ACBK including the National Reports and Project Reports there was no significant transboundary communication between enforcement officers during the reporting period.

2.4 Strengthen national capacity and legislation, where appropriate, to support improvements in detection, processing and prosecution of offenders, including measures to avoid conflicts of interest.

- 37 No major changes to national legislation have been made in Saiga Range states during the reporting period. More information about capacity is provided in 2.5

2.5 Improve the prestige, capacity, social security and coordination of, and provide relevant training for, local and national law enforcement and nature protection officers and other officials, at all levels, where appropriate.

- 38 In **Kazakhstan** training for customs and law enforcement officers on Saiga-related issues is conducted on a project basis with the participation of NGOs such as ACBK, which recently organized training in collaboration with the Academy of Law Enforcement under the Prosecutor General's Office of Kazakhstan.

- 39 ACBK together with a group of experts has developed a course for advanced training on the application of CITES in Kazakhstan for law enforcement officers and border services directly or indirectly engaged in environmental activities. In August 2023, 28 people from the teaching staff of educational organizations of law enforcement agencies and the border guard service were trained in Almaty. In September 2023, ACBK held an international round table in Astana with the participation of representatives of law enforcement (prosecutors) and the environmental agencies of Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan and Uzbekistan, who exchanged experiences on the application of CITES in Central Asian countries and discussed gaps in national legislation.
- 40 Furthermore, a new national professional training programme was developed and successfully piloted for state rangers, Nature Protection Police, Okhotzooptom, governmental agencies, and the trainers of police and ranger academies. The training is based on international best practices and covers topics such as improving skills in countering wildlife trade, interaction of nature protection agencies with different stakeholders (communities, offenders, and poachers), illegal wildlife trade crime prevention strategies, first aid, de-escalation of conflict, survival in extreme conditions, terrain orientation and the use of technology and equipment for the prevention and suppression of offences including wildlife crime.
- 41 In **Mongolia** law enforcement officials were trained in partnership with the National Police Agency, the Prosecutor General's Office of Mongolia, and the Council for Environmental Crime Prevention and other relevant law enforcement agencies and institutions, to increase awareness of legislation concerning Saiga. They also received training in identifying Saiga parts and derivatives.
- 42 WWF Mongolia has developed standardized basic level training modules for rangers approved by the government in March 2024. These standardized training modules will deliver all the necessary knowledge and skills for wildlife rangers through basic, intermediate and advanced levels of 120-hour lectures and on-the-ground practice training.
- 43 WWF Mongolia has also been facilitating initiatives aimed at fostering enhanced cooperation between government agencies on tackling wildlife crime, elevating the expertise of personnel, and organizing collaborative training sessions. As part of this endeavor, the Department of Training and Research under the Prosecutor General's Office of Mongolia and WWF Mongolia, in cooperation with the sub-commission on prevention of environmental crime in Mongolia, organized capacity training titled "Crime against the environment and prosecutor's control" in Ulaanbaatar in September 2023. This training involved the participation of 40 deputy prosecutors from Prosecutor's Offices across 21 provinces and the Capital of Mongolia.
- 44 Additionally, WWF Mongolia, in cooperation with the National Police Agency, supported training for 142 police officers on tactics to tackle illegal logging and illegal wildlife crime, among other topics. The training involved mostly newly recruited officers and took place in 2023 in Ulaanbaatar.
- 45 WWF Mongolia also cooperates with the Department of Ecological Police providing online training sessions for newly recruited police officers and refresher-training for active officers on combating environmental crime cases and the identification of illegally traded wild animal and plant species in different forms. Online training modules were created for this purpose. The National Police Agency made these modules accessible for all police officers.

- 46 Mongolian customs and border protection agencies have a policy to replace their staff every few years, transferring them from one border point to another as a corruption prevention measure. This requires regular training. WWF Mongolia has provided mobile on-the-job training in 5 border points in Mongolia. The training was created in cooperation with experts from the Sub-Commission on Prevention of Environmental Crime and the National University of Mongolia. 128 law enforcement officers received training on topics such as recent changes in the legal framework, investigation and resolution of crimes and offences of illegal trading of wildlife and plants and the identification of wildlife species and their parts.
- 47 In May 2024, as part of the USFWS funded project “Tackling Saiga antelope horn sourcing and trafficking in Mongolia through an evidence-based approach to improve law and policy enforcement activities”, a 2-day training course took place for enforcement leaders to help improve the performance and impact of their agencies in protecting wildlife in Mongolia.
- 48 Customs and law enforcement officers in the Russian Federation are fully informed about the legislation concerning Saiga and CITES regulations. There are no issues regarding the implementation of CITES decisions.
- 49 **Uzbekistan’s** Ministry of Ecology, Environmental Protection, and Climate Change regularly conducts practical seminars for customs and other law enforcement officers to prevent violations related to biodiversity use. From 2020 to 2024, the Ministry, along with national and international organizations, conducted a series of training workshops to strengthen the efficiency and interagency cooperation of customs, border services, law enforcement and organizations involved in wildlife conservation.

2.7 Monitor and measure anti-poaching efforts and impacts, and use these analyses to inform improved anti-poaching strategies.

- 50 **Kazakhstan.** The number of detected poaching cases has remained stable, ranging from 47 to 82 annually. Since 2021, 168 cases of Saiga poaching have been identified. As a result, 168 criminal cases have been initiated, and the convicted individuals had to compensate the state for damages amounting to 4,872,552,999 KZT (USD 10,151,152).
- 51 **Mongolia.** Anti-poaching efforts have been bolstered through enhanced law enforcement, collaboration between rangers and police, and the confiscation of horns. Since the implementation of the SMART system in 2017, no Saiga poaching cases have been reported, demonstrating the success of these combined efforts in protecting the species.
- 52 **Russian Federation.** During the reporting period, no poaching incidents were recorded in the North-West Pre-Caspian region. However, in the Volga region, isolated cases of poaching were noted (5 Saigas, Saratov region, August 2023), which was linked to the mass migration of Saigas from Kazakhstan and the resulting pressure on agricultural fields and pastures.
- 53 **Uzbekistan.** No cases of illegal Saiga hunting were recorded in Uzbekistan during the reporting period.

3.0 Sustainable use and trade

3.1 Encourage research aiming to understand and reduce the demand for and quantity of Saiga horn used in traditional Asian medicines, including market surveys, both on the ground and online, in Range States, consumer and trading countries.

- 54 In Mongolia WCS Mongolia conducted a household survey in 2023 using Unmatched Count Techniques to investigate Saiga horn sourcing and trafficking, interviewing 854 households across Saiga range areas. Initial findings suggest local consumption of saiga horn, possibly collected during mass mortality events, but further study is needed. Since October 2022, WCS has also studied the Saiga horn supply chain in China, confirming its use in Traditional Chinese Medicine (TCM). With at least 112 TCM formulas containing Saiga horn available, interventions to reduce prescriptions have been developed. Legal risk documents on online trade were shared with 516 law enforcement offices via WeChat.
- 55 TRAFFIC International, supported by USFWS, is helping Malaysia's DWNP establish a Saiga horn stockpile management system. The first inventory of registered TCM shops in Peninsular Malaysia, completed in November 2024, provides a baseline for managing Saiga stockpiles.
- 56 A project by the University of Oxford and the National University of Singapore examines Saiga horn demand in Japan and Singapore, aiming to design behavior change interventions based on consumer insights.
- 57 In Kazakhstan, ACBK analyzed 2019–2024 wildlife trade activity, identifying 202 poaching-related news items, 314 illegal sales on the online platform “OLX”, and submitting 31 police appeals. TRAFFIC also released a 2023 report on wildlife trade dynamics in four Central Asian countries, based on data from ACBK and partners.

3.4 Encourage all Range States, and Saiga trading and consuming countries to report seizures or confiscations through appropriate channels as part of annual reporting to CITES and Interpol and encourage trading partners to do the same.

- 58 Kazakhstan submitted an annual report for 2023 to the CITES Secretariat about legal and illegal trade in Saiga derivatives. In its National Report, Kazakhstan notes that a total of 20,912 Saiga horns have been confiscated from illegal circulation since 2021. The data shows an increase in the confiscation of Saiga derivatives from the illegal market: in 2021, 3,509 horns were confiscated; 6,539 horns in 2022; 10,223 horns in 2023; and 641 horns in 2024 (at the time of the report submission).
- 59 The rising trend is attributed to the significant rise in Saiga numbers, the natural mortality of male Saigas, and the illegal collection of horns from deceased animals by local people. Confiscated Saiga products and derivatives in Kazakhstan are subject to destruction. No information was provided for other countries.

3.6 Encourage countries trading in Saiga parts and derivatives to establish internal market controls e.g. through registration, control and monitoring of stockpiles, including confiscated products; labelling of parts and products; registration of manufacturers and traders; and verifying the source and legality of Saiga products in trade, learning from experiences with marking and identification of wildlife parts and derivatives.

- 60 The 19th Meeting of the Conference of the Parties to CITES (November 2022) adopted the Decisions 19.213 – 19.217 on Saiga Antelopes.
- 61 In November 2023, a delegation from Kazakhstan participated in the CITES Standing Committee meeting, where Kazakhstan presented updated information on the Saiga population recovery and the beginning of population management. Kazakhstan, supported by the United States, suggested that Decision 19.213, paragraph b), be renewed and expanded to include consumer Parties as well as Range States. CITES Standing Committee agreed to revise and renew Decision 19.213 to encourage both

range States and consumer States to establish internal market controls for Saiga parts, including registration of stockpiles, labelling of parts and products, and registration of manufacturers and traders, and report such information to the CITES Secretariat.

- 62 TRAFFIC is implementing a project: "Taking Stock: Establishing an effective Saiga horn stockpile management system in Malaysia". The project is currently carrying out a first-of-its-kind inventory of the quantity and distribution of Saiga horn stockpiles held in registered traditional Chinese medicine shops in Peninsular Malaysia. The inventory has been conducted in eight states so far. The inventory exercise will establish a baseline of Saiga stockpiles in this consumer state.

3.7 Seek opportunities for training and cross-border cooperation in CITES implementation, identification of Saiga products and techniques for countering illegal trade.

- 63 ACBK organized an event for law enforcement officers using service dogs from Kazakhstan and Kyrgyzstan to share approaches, results, and explore cross-border cooperation. Experts from the U.S.-based organization "Working Dogs for Conservation," were invited to share their expertise.
- 64 In March 2023, a two-day workshop was held at Kazakhstan's Cynology Center of the Agency on Financial Monitoring. Participants included representatives from customs services of Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan, Tajikistan, Georgia, and the Czech Republic. The workshop facilitated knowledge exchange across six countries and trained three Kyrgyz service dogs to detect wildlife derivatives such as bear paws and Saiga horns.

3.8 Improve collaboration amongst Range States to halt illegal trade in Saiga parts and derivatives by further harmonizing legislation and strengthening its implementation (including work with judiciary and prosecutors) and enhancing cross-border enforcement and training.

- 65 In July 2023, the Ministry of Natural Resources, Ecology and Technical Supervision of the Kyrgyz Republic hosted a meeting in Bishkek to strengthen cooperation between organizations in Kazakhstan, Kyrgyzstan and Uzbekistan involved in combating illegal trafficking of wild animal and plant species in Central Asian countries in this area, organized by TRAFFIC. The event drew 66 participants from across the region as well as representatives from the UK and Chinese Governments, the CITES Secretariat and the EU, among others. See also 3.7.

3.10 Initiate research on the feasibility, conditions and requirements for sustainable use of specific populations of Saiga antelopes, taking into consideration all relevant factors including disease and mass mortality events, sustainable harvest levels, population thresholds, demographic structure of populations, socioeconomic aspects, compliance with CITES regulations (e.g. Non-Detriment Findings), capacity to monitor and control utilisation and trade, and ability to identify and trace Saiga derivatives in trade.

- 66 In September 2023 the Government of Kazakhstan decided to cull Saiga of the Ural and Betpak-Dala populations to reduce their number. The feasibility study for this activity was prepared by Zhangir Khan West Kazakhstan Agrarian and Technical University. Concerns about the quality of this document were raised among the expert community both in Kazakhstan and internationally. The culling was carried out by the State Enterprise "Okhotzoooprom" from October 10 to December 10, 2023, was paused during the critical Saiga mating period, and then continued from January 10 to February 10, 2024.
- 67 In 2023 a scientific paper was published about the use of nuclear microsatellites, previously developed for the study of natural Saiga populations, as genetic markers to

establish the origin of Saiga derivatives to curb their illicit trafficking internationally (Zinevich et al., 2023). An analysis of 156 samples of Saiga horns from the population of the Northwestern Caspian Sea alongside confiscated batches of suspected origin from the Republic of Kazakhstan showed that autosomal microsatellite loci are not able to identify any differences between Saiga derivatives originating from the territory of the Russian Federation and the Republic of Kazakhstan.

3.11 Use in future activities the outcomes contained in the CMS report "Sustainable Use of Saiga Antelope: Perspectives and Prospects", when appropriate.

- 68 The CMS report "The Sustainable Use of Saiga Antelopes: Perspectives and Prospects" endorsed by the Fourth Meeting of Signatories to the Saiga MOU (Saiga MOS4). As the number of Saigas in Kazakhstan increased during the reporting period since 2021, the level of conflict between agricultural stakeholders and Saigas escalated. The Government of Kazakhstan has initiated identification of possible solutions to these conflicts.
- 69 Upon the initiative of the Government of Kazakhstan, the CMS Secretariat organized consultative meetings bringing together international and national experts and various stakeholders to discuss solutions for conflicts between farmers and Saiga and a way forward for Saiga conservation and management in Kazakhstan. The online meeting took place from 28 February- 1 March 2023, and the in-person workshop from 25-27 May 2023. During these meetings the participants developed and endorsed [the Conservation and Management Strategy for Saiga in Kazakhstan](#) building on the abovementioned CMS report.
- 70 The Government of Kazakhstan experienced challenges in implementing the Strategy, thus another meeting was organized on 9 September 2024 which endorsed [Next Steps in implementing the Strategy](#). Furthermore, parts of the strategy were suggested to be integrated into a 'comprehensive plan' (kompleksniy plan') on Saiga Antelopes in Kazakhstan.
- 71 In all other Range States sustainable use of Saiga is currently not considered an option due to the species' legal status (See 3.1 Legal Status of the Species).

3.12 Establish or strengthen strict and transparent national control mechanisms for Saiga parts and derivatives from confiscations, natural mortality or sustainable use in Range States and consumer countries including proper methods for marking, registration and storage of specimen, which are safe against misuse and are built on international best practice.

- 72 During CMS COP14 in Samarkand in 2024, multiple online and in-person meetings were organized by Kazakhstan with representatives from the CITES Secretariat, TRAFFIC Malaysia, and other international organizations to discuss stockpile management issues.
- 73 Kazakhstan has initiated the development and implementation of national control measures for Saiga parts and derivatives obtained through the culling of Saiga by state employees. As a result of culling in the Ural and Betpak-Dala populations, a total of 42,161 Saiga horns were collected in 2023–2024. Each horn has been individually numbered, marked, and recorded in the inventory of the State Enterprise "Okhotzooptom," where they are securely stored. To ensure proper accounting, each horn is sealed with a tamper-evident clamp that can only be removed by cutting, preventing unauthorized access.

- 74 Mongolian legislation strictly prohibits hunting, possession, and domestic trade of Saiga and its parts under the Law on Fauna. Violations, including illegal trade, are subject to severe penalties such as fines, imprisonment, and confiscation. Exceptions are allowed for scientific and educational purposes, but these require special permits from relevant authorities. Saiga horn stocks in Mongolia are relatively small, primarily consisting of seizures by customs and law enforcement from illegal traders, poachers, and at border crossings. There is currently no centralized monitoring system, hindering accurate reporting on the size, source, and ownership of these stocks. Efforts are underway to establish a 'Chain of Custody' and develop a storage and monitoring protocol. This involves interviewing anti-poaching rangers, law enforcement, forensic police, and other stakeholders to document existing practices. Additionally, the legal framework is being reviewed to determine which agency has jurisdiction over these stockpiles. Confiscated Saiga horns are mostly destroyed, with a smaller number preserved for training, research, and educational purposes.
- 75 In the Russian Federation ownership of Saiga products and derivatives is completely prohibited, and since 2013, criminal liability has been enforced. There is no domestic market for Saiga products at all. Seized Saiga horns are stored as evidence during investigations and trials. After the legal process is concluded, the horns are destroyed. Some horns are transferred to research institutions for scientific purposes with CITES administrative approval.
- 76 In Uzbekistan no instances of international trade in Saiga products were detected during the reporting period. There are no official stockpiles of Saiga products in Uzbekistan, though there are illegally traded horns used for making national souvenirs of unknown quantity.

3.13 Involve all stakeholders, including representatives of local communities, in the planning process for national systems of sustainable use of the Saiga antelope.

- 77 The Government of Kazakhstan has organized several meetings in Astana and Uralsk inviting representatives of Governmental bodies, research institutions, NGOs, hunting and farming associations, local government to discuss approaches to the sustainable use of the Saiga antelope. In addition, representatives of the Ministry and its Forestry and Wildlife Committee (FWC) organized several meetings with local community representatives in West Kazakhstan villages. Local community representatives from West Kazakhstan region took part in the consultative meetings facilitated by the CMS Secretariat in 2023, contributing to the development and endorsement of the Conservation and Management Strategy for Saiga in Kazakhstan (see 3.11 above).

4.0 Work with local people



4.1 Strengthen the involvement of different stakeholders in Saiga conservation, and encourage local involvement in, and support for, Saiga protection.

- 78 At the Ustyurt range in Kazakhstan, the Tabigi Orta Association of local NGOs, supported by NABU involves local communities in Saiga conservation activities. Since 2022, Tabigi Orta is the legal proprietor of the 5,000 km² Diyar Game Management Area for the conservation and sustainable use of wildlife. Its rangers protect the area and conduct monitoring. This area includes key habitats of the Ustyurt Saiga subpopulation. The Conservation and Management Strategy for Saiga in Kazakhstan and the recommendations from the report Potential for Community-Based Wildlife Management in Central Asia outline policy options aimed at enhancing the involvement of local communities in conservation efforts.

4.2 Monitor attitudes of local people towards Saiga conservation activities and threats to Saiga, using local-level social research including participatory community monitoring.

- 79 Kazakhstan. Research of the University of Greifswald examines human-wildlife conflict related to pasture use by livestock and Saiga in West Kazakhstan, which began in 2019 due to pasture degradation and land-use planning without consideration for wildlife. Farmers near Saiga calving areas (April–June) face the most impact.
- 80 Since 2022, ACBK and ADCI have surveyed conflict areas, starting near Bokey Orda Reserve and expanding to four districts in 2023. Under the Whitley Award 2023 project, water conflicts were analyzed using GIS, remote sensing, groundwater data, Saiga migration maps, and 40 interviews with local farmers. The resulting recommendations aim to address water use issues and promote coexistence between Saigas and local communities. These recommendations will become available to the FWC shortly.
- 81 In Mongolia, understanding local perspectives is crucial for effective conservation. In September 2023, a KAP (knowledge, attitude, and practice) survey of 632 residents from 7 soums in Khovd and Gobi-Altai provinces assessed attitudes towards Mongolian Saiga and the impact of communication efforts. Key findings include:
 - **Ecological awareness:** 74.7% recognized the ecological importance of the Mongolian Saiga, an 11% decrease from 2020, highlighting the need for ongoing awareness efforts.
 - **Reporting illegal activities:** The willingness to report Saiga poaching or trade dropped from 48.3% in 2020 to 41% in 2023, possibly reflecting the absence of recent poaching rather than a shift in attitudes, warranting further investigation.
 - **Support for spring protection:** 76% supported protecting natural springs, with 63.3% willing to engage in voluntary conservation efforts.
- 82 This highlights the need for sustained outreach and community engagement to bolster conservation efforts.
- 83 In Uzbekistan, as part of the Whitley Fund for Nature (WFN) and People's Trust for Endangered Species (PTES) projects titled "Resurrection Island: Working with local communities and the government to restore biodiversity and develop sustainable livelihoods" and the Darwin Initiative project "Resurrection Island: enterprise, conservation and development around the Aral Sea," sociological studies were conducted in the Muynak district of Karakalpakstan in 2022 and 2024. These studies focused on local attitudes towards Saiga and explored sustainable development opportunities in the Aral Sea region.
- 84 Additionally, under the joint project funded by USFWS and implemented by Fauna & Flora, Saiga Conservation Alliance and ACBK, titled "Strengthening local capacity to lead evidence-based conservation of Saiga in their native habitats in Kazakhstan and Uzbekistan," a study was conducted to examine public attitudes towards illegal hunting and Saiga trafficking. The resulting report titled "Forensics and crime scenario: from poaching to Saiga smuggling in Uzbekistan" looked at the drivers of illegal activities among residents of Kungrad district villages. In Kazakhstan, crime scripting was developed for the Ural and Betpak-Dala Saiga populations.

4.4 Promote sustainable rangeland use to enable the cohabitation of people, livestock and Saiga antelopes.

- 85 WWF Mongolia is implementing a project called: "Protect 100 springs to support 1000 herder families to sustain 15,000 Mongolian Saiga antelopes". The project aims to

protect at least 100 of the most depleted natural springs in the current Saiga range, and build a coalition of local communities, ecoclub members (children) and local authorities around these sites to protect and champion them, to ensure water availability for both Mongolian Saiga and local communities. Key approaches to securing sustainable water use include community consultation, commitment building, joint restoration and fencing of the source points, support for local communities to maintain and monitor restored springs.

4.5 Expand current incentive-based and conservation-linked livelihood-improvement projects and develop new programmes in all appropriate parts of the Saiga range.

- 86 WWF Mongolia has supported good governance and market access for agricultural herders' cooperatives in the Altai-Sayan Ecoregion ASER for years, enhancing livelihoods and reducing the pressure on wildlife habitat from increasing livestock numbers. Partnering with the National Association of Mongolian Agricultural Cooperatives (NAMAC), WWF provides professional consulting services to 10 cooperatives across 10 soums, involving about 20% of households. In 2023, cooperative membership grew by 2%, with 97% being herding families. Active assets reached 2,472 million Mongolian tugrik (approximately 670,000 EUR), and gross profits totaled 4,184 million Mongolian tugrik from selling wool, cashmere, meat, dairy products, and skins. By streamlining raw product supply, cooperatives save herders time, reduce costs, and enable direct market access at fair prices

4.7 Build on pilot projects for Saiga-based tourism and, where appropriate, promote this as a useful approach to increase local engagement in conservation, and create incentives for local people to conserve Saiga antelopes.

- 87 In Kazakhstan, "Tabigi Orta" Association of community-based NGOs has managed the 5,000 km² Diyar Wildlife Management Area, aiming to protect and sustainably use wildlife (see section 4.1). This area encompasses critical habitats of the Ustyurt Saiga population. In 2024, NABU and Tabigi Orta initiated a pilot program for community-based eco-tourism and plans to expand these activities. Future initiatives may include hunting tourism, if hunting quotas are issued for selected species.

4.8 Explore options for a potential future sustainable use system with involvement of local people from the start, ensuring that benefits are created to incentivize local people to conserve Saiga antelopes.

- 88 Kazakhstan is developing a national system of sustainable use of Saiga. For information on the involvement of local communities in sustainable use planning, please refer to section 3.13 above.

5.0 Awareness

5.1 Develop and implement awareness-raising and training activities, and promote the dissemination of best practice examples, information materials, and workshop outputs for professional stakeholders involved in controlling illegal use of Saiga.

- 89 Representatives of the Governmental bodies of Kazakhstan met several times with CITES Secretariat, TRAFFIC Malaysia and the Elephant Protection Fund to identify best practices for stockpile management systems. For details please see section 2.5.

5.3 Ensure local communities within the Saiga range remain aware of the conservation and legal status of Saigas.

- 90 Kazakhstan. Okhotzooptom rangers conducted 5,748 outreach sessions to raise awareness about Saiga conservation among local people. Draft laws and regulations, excluding restricted information, are published on the legal acts portal for public feedback. Through the state service eotinish.kz, the Committee for Forestry and Wildlife has issued 1,018 clarifications about Saigas since 2021. Queries included compensation mechanisms for Saiga-related damage and regulation of Saiga population numbers in Kazakhstan, submitted by farmers and local authorities.
- 91 Mongolia. Public awareness about the Mongolian Saiga has grown significantly thanks to efforts by the government, conservation organizations, and local communities, highlighting the endangered status of Saiga, its importance and the threats it faces. A six-part puppetry series on rare Gobi animals, created by the Mongolian Puppetry Theatre, reached 45,000 viewers via social media and Khovd TV, with sign language accessibility. Local engagement also included documentary screenings like The Sprinter of the Desert Steppe, airport and roadside billboards, and Earth Hour campaigns supporting water springs protection in the Gobi.
- 92 The annual “Let’s Preserve Our Nature” campaign, held from 15 April to 15 May 2024, aimed to promote positive environmental actions. Coordinated by the Sub-commission on Environmental Crime Prevention, it featured WWF-supported activities in Ulaanbaatar and Khovd province. Outputs included 13 videos, 8 reels, 15 interviews, 10 news articles, 26 posters, and 114 social media posts.
- 93 In the Russian Federation, thanks to the efforts by protected area staff and collaborating scientific organizations, local communities in the range of the North-West Pre-Caspian Saiga population are well-informed about the species’ uniqueness, local conservation activities, and prohibitions of hunting. Protected areas also feature ecological trails, visitor centers with exhibits, and printed materials like brochures and souvenirs featuring Saiga images. The SCA, until recently, supported various events, including creative competitions and workshops, providing small grants for these initiatives.

5.4 Continue to develop, update and widely implement a range of educational activities and materials on Saiga ecology and conservation for children in Range States.

- 94 Kazakhstan. In collaboration with the SCA, ACBK supports Saiga clubs in schools and communities across the Ustyurt and Betpak-Dala Saiga ranges. During the reporting period, ACBK organized annual ‘Saiga Day’ festivals, field trips for schoolchildren, quizzes, and contests. More than 80 thematic lessons were conducted in Ustyurt range schools, reaching 2,000 students. New educational materials include ACBK’s Animals of Kazakhstan’s Steppe and the Kazakh children’s magazine Akboken. Additionally, the ‘Students for Nature’ project actively engages university students specializing in biology, ecology, and zoology.
- 95 Mongolia. “Saiga Day” is celebrated annually with eco-club students, involving field trips and activities that reach thousands of schoolchildren.
- 96 Russian Federation. “Saiga Day” is celebrated annually across the Saiga range in Russia. In the Republic of Kalmykia (since 2013) and the Orenburg region (since 2015), “Steppe Day” is a regional festival. These events are widely covered in the media.

- 97 Uzbekistan. "Saiga Day" has been celebrated in villages throughout the Saiga range (Kungirat and Muynak districts) and in Nukus for several years. This event gained national importance when, on May 31, 2023, the President of Uzbekistan signed a decree establishing it as a national environmental event. In 2024, "Saiga Day" was celebrated in Karakalpakstan and Tashkent regions. In 2023, a coloring book was published, entitled "Fauna of Uzbekistan: Karakalpakstan (deserts and semi-deserts)". Furthermore, the head of the Republic of Karakalpakstan declared 2024 the "Year of the Saiga". These measures aim to integrate Saiga conservation into the national environmental agenda and foster broader ecological awareness in Uzbekistan.

5.6 Develop and widely implement awareness-raising campaigns, through all relevant media, to raise the profile of Saigas at local, national and international levels.

- 98 Several side events at CMS COP14 were dedicated to Saiga or where Saiga was mentioned as an example of a particular conservation issue or solution. The Government of Kazakhstan organized the side event titled "Recognising and building on the success of transboundary cooperation on the recovery of Saiga Antelope in Central Asia" which featured presentations from Saiga Range States and conservation organisations, highlighting the international cooperation for Saiga conservation and celebrating success. Another event titled 'Use it or lose it: Merging local benefits & sustainable Saiga management' was organized by the German NGO Nature Conservation Union (NABU) likewise involving different stakeholders to discuss prospects of sustainable use of Saiga. The Saiga Conservation Alliance supported by the Altyn Dala Conservation Initiative, furthermore, hosted a Saiga Networking Event, which gave room for discussions of Saiga conservation topics and enhanced networking. Twelve governmental briefings on Saiga conservation issues have been broadcasted on Kazakhstan's national television during the reporting period. See also section 5.3.
- 99 To raise the international profile of Saiga conservation work by the Altyn Dala Conservation Initiative¹, representatives of the initiative participated in international meetings, congresses and workshops at technical and political levels. Some of the events are:
- May 2022: 2nd Asian Parks Congress (Sabah, Malaysia). Connectivity and transboundary conservation and effective protected and conserved areas.
 - June 2022: CMS Intersessional Working Group (IWG) on linear infrastructure. Key questions connected with Saiga migration and barriers for goitered gazelle's migration.
 - December 2022 in Montreal, Canada: 15th meeting of the Conference of the Parties to the Convention on Biological Diversity. During this CoP ADCl was awarded as a UN World Restoration Flagship (together with 9 other Restoration Projects selected around the World).
 - April 2023 London: the Whitley Fund for Nature (WFN) was awarded Albert Salemgareyev from ACBK — a prestigious award for his conservation work with the Saiga antelope in Kazakhstan.
 - November 2023 Ashgabat: Regional Workshop on Conservation of Migratory Species in Central Asia: effects on transboundary cooperation in protected areas. Discussions around our work creating crossing points for migration of ungulates and other mammals through border fences

¹ The Altyn Dala Conservation Initiative is a partnership of the government of Kazakhstan, national and international NGOs to conserve and restore grassland ecosystems of Kazakhstan.

- December 2023 Dubai: side event “Climate benefits of large-scale conservation and restoration of steppe grassland ecosystems organized by the UN Decade for Restoration” at the Twenty Eighth Conference of the Parties to the UN Framework Convention on Climate Change (UNFCCC).

5.7 Support and regularly update existing websites about Saiga conservation, restoration and sustainable use, including the maintenance of the official CMS Saiga MOU website and the online Saiga Resource Centre.

100 The CMS Saiga MOU website and the Saiga Resource Center website are described under section 1.3 and are being updated on a regular basis. The Altyn Dala Conservation Initiative has created and continuously updates its own website (<https://altyndala.org/>).

5.8 Expand the distribution and profile of Saiga News, both in hard copy and in electronic version, at local level and through other national and international media.

101 Described in detail in section 1.3

5.9 Monitor the effectiveness of awareness-raising campaigns in changing the behaviour of relevant groups towards better Saiga conservation.

102 Some information was obtained from WWF Mongolia's triennial KAP (Knowledge, Attitude, Practice) surveys on attitudes toward Mongolian Saiga and the effectiveness of communication efforts (see section 4.2) survey.

6.0 Habitat and environmental factors

6.1 Remove or mitigate barriers to Saiga movement (fences, roads, railways and other linear infrastructure) in line with CMS Guidelines on Mitigating the Impact of Linear Infrastructure and Related Disturbance on Mammals in Central Asia (Resolution 11.24) and internationally recognized standards IFC1 and IFC6.

103 Kazakhstan. Since 2021, the ADCI is involved in the Global Initiative on Ungulate Migration (GIUM). The main aim of the initiative is to work collaboratively to: 1) create a Global Atlas of Ungulate Migration (an inventory) using tracking data and expert knowledge; and 2) stimulate research on drivers, mechanisms, threats and conservation solutions common to ungulate migration worldwide. Saiga population is now one of 20 mapped populations available in the Global Atlas on Ungulate Migration, a growing effort to document the world's ungulate migrations and make corridor maps available to conservation planners.

104 During the reporting period, ACBK strengthened cooperation with Kazakhstan's Border Service. In 2023, 19 camera traps were installed along the Kazakhstan-Uzbekistan border fence, confirming that Saigas cross where passages exist. However, in other places barriers like border fences between Kazakhstan and Russia, and Kazakhstan and Uzbekistan remained unchanged. Uzbekistan's National Report highlights the fence along the Kazakh and Uzbek border and the “Shalkar – Beyneu” railway in Kazakhstan as major obstacles to Saiga migration.

105 Mongolia. In response to rapidly increasing linear infrastructure development, a coordination platform on wildlife friendly linear infrastructure development was established as a permanent working group under the direct administration of the Ministry of Environment and Tourism of Mongolia to specifically coordinate related parties and safeguard the wildlife friendly linear infrastructure in Mongolia.

- 106 WWF Mongolia has created reliable prediction maps for target species in crucial connectivity areas. In this reporting period in the frame of the USAID-funded Asia's Linear Infrastructure safeGuarding Nature (ALIGN) project, WWF Mongolia has produced comprehensive maps, a database and recommendations on reducing the impact of existing and planned linear infrastructure on key endangered and migratory species of mammals as well as birds of Mongolia. This database was presented at the second meeting of the recently established Coordination platform on wildlife friendly linear infrastructure development in September 2023.

6.2 Encourage government authorities, investors and developers to ensure that all proposed infrastructural, natural resource extraction, and other developments likely to impact Saiga and its habitat are subject to a full Social and Environmental Impact Assessment (SEIA) and/or Strategic Environmental Assessment (SEA), following international best practice.

- 107 Mongolia. Fencing along Mongolia's railroads, designed to keep livestock off the tracks, has become a major environmental concern, blocking wildlife movement and fragmenting habitats. As climate change shifts migration patterns, revising fencing regulations is increasingly urgent. In response, the Mongolian government, supported by international NGOs, introduced a national wildlife-friendly fencing standard. Approved in May 2024, it bans barbed wire and mandates designs that allow wildlife to pass underneath or jump over while still restricting livestock access.
- 108 Russian Federation. A comprehensive assessment of proposed developments in the Saiga range has not been conducted. Strategic planning that considers all factors is not being implemented. Evaluations of impacts are conducted selectively during the development and planning of specific projects to prevent the death of wildlife. For example, The Stavropol-Elista-Astrakhan road reconstruction project includes the creation of Saiga crossings and the installation of appropriate road signs.
- 109 Uzbekistan. A Biodiversity Conservation Plan was developed during the reconstruction of the A380 high-speed highway, which includes measures to mitigate the road's impact on Saigas, such as special passages and to restore biodiversity overall. Other infrastructure projects do not conduct impact assessments and create impassable or poorly passable barriers (for example, a 2-meter embankment over the gas pipeline at the Western Aral field, Aralkum, built in 2023-2024).

6.3 Collate and analyse information on Saiga habitat and range use, present and past; identify key features, including habitat types used and the effects of anthropogenic factors, including climate change, and identify key habitats based on this analysis.

- 110 Kazakhstan. In 2021, ACBK used the MaxEnt model to estimate potential Saiga habitats in Kazakhstan, analyzing occurrence data (2009–2020) and spatial habitat requirements. The model identified 746,424 km² of potential habitat, while the species currently occupies 222,460 km². In June 2024, ACBK began assessing the climate vulnerability of key steppe species, including Saiga, to guide the development of a resilient ecological network in West Kazakhstan, centered around Bokey Orda reserve. A study on Saiga's historical and current distribution by ACBK and the Frankfurt Zoological Society (FZS) is forthcoming, along with a Species Distribution Model under the ADCI framework.
- 111 Mongolia. A spatially explicit model, utilizing long-term data, revealed that approximately 30% of the Saiga range in Mongolia consists of suitable habitat, while the remaining 70% is degraded or rendered less suitable due to factors such as livestock overgrazing, human disturbance, and climate change.

- 112 Russian Federation. Since 2018, the scientific research plan of the Institute of Ecology and Evolution of the Russian Academy of Sciences (Saiga tatarica Conservation Research Program) has included work on modeling the updated Saiga range in Russia based on remote sensing data and field geobotanical research. It also includes assessing the degree of habitat fragmentation, calculating potential green (ecological) corridors for the animals, and assessing options and possibilities for restoring Saiga migration routes in the event of a population increase. Fragmentation of the range is occurring due to land plowing and the process of habitat aridization. Studies have been conducted on suitable habitats in Kalmykia and the Astrakhan region, as well as on the grazing capacity of these lands.

6.4 Analyse scenarios of likely future change in Saiga distribution, range use, abundance, demography and threats due to climate change, infrastructure and other human factors, and recommend responses accordingly, through revisions to the MTIWP.

- 113 Kazakhstan. In 2023 ACBK and the UK's Royal Society for the Protection of Birds (RSPB) began to assess land use and land cover change in the Ural population area in the framework of the ADCI. The goal is to understand drivers of change in the landscape that will be used to identify possible future scenarios of land use that may affect the quality of the steppe ecosystems and impacts on the Saiga population.

6.5 Facilitate exchange of data on Saiga and Saiga habitat among range states and stakeholders, using the Saiga Resource Centre if appropriate.

- 114 Through the Saiga Conservation Alliance, scientists and conservationists working on Saiga are well connected and already sharing data. Research outcomes are published in peer-reviewed journals and in the Saiga News.

6.6 Develop integrated rangeland management plans including resource partitioning for key Saiga sites.

- 115 Mongolia. Wildlife-friendly pasture management initiatives launched in 2023 in four soums have progressed significantly, with approximately 80% of plans successfully implemented. Stakeholder engagement—including key consultations, specialized training, and expert guidance—has strengthened local authorities and pasture specialists, fostering more efficient management.

- 116 In the past six months, herders, benefiting from training on pasture use and herd turnover in the framework of a WWF project, have increasingly adopted livestock rotation and market participation. Analysis of four districts implementing the plan showed a 15% reduction in average livestock numbers, with Bayan-Uul soum (Gobi-Altai) achieving a notable 25% decrease, reflecting a shift toward sustainable practices. Additionally, Turgen soum's Governor's Office (Uvs) issued notices to four herder households in wildlife breeding areas, successfully preventing pasture overlap during breeding season.

7.0 Protected areas

7.1 Enhance national protected area networks to benefit Saiga, with particular emphasis on protecting key areas (birthing and rutting) and migration corridors, based on the recommendations from 6.3.

- 117 In Kazakhstan, during the reporting period, two new protected areas were established within the Ural Saiga population's range: the Bokey Orda State Nature Reserve and the Ashyozek Nature Sanctuary. Supported by ACBK, the Wyss Foundation, and RSPB,

protected area staff in these areas received over 250 pieces of equipment, intensive training, and assistance in developing a management plan.

- 118 As a result, 5.5% of the Saiga range in Kazakhstan is now under protection, with 90% of these areas covering critical habitats such as calving and mating grounds. While protected areas exist for the Betpak-Dala and Ural populations, none have been designated for the Ustyurt population. Currently, Kazakhstan has no plans to establish additional protected areas within the Saiga range.
- 119 Mongolia. By 2024, approximately 33% of the Saiga range will be included in protected area networks. Nine protected areas are located within the Saiga range, with a total area of 2,103,400 hectares. There are plans to create a protected area of 180,000 hectares, which will include calving and mating areas. See 15.1 for more information. (See also population –specific measures in section 15).
- 120 Russian Federation. The total area of protected regions within the range of the North-Western Caspian Saiga population is 771,500 hectares, representing 7.7% of the species' potential maximum habitat. Currently, 77% of the population's range falls within protected areas. However, existing protections—including those without dedicated administrations—offer only minimal coverage, safeguarding approximately 14% of the key Ural Saiga concentration zones in the Trans-Volga region and an additional 17% in the border zone.
- 121 Protection levels vary significantly across different areas. For example, around Lake Baskunchak, nearly 90% of the habitat is protected, whereas coverage is much lower in other regions—just 10% in the Kharabali area and 19% in the territory between the Dyura and Altata rivers.
- 122 There are plans to expand the buffer zone of the "Chernye Zemli" Reserve to include critical calving grounds for the North-West Pre-Caspian Saiga population. However, no protected areas currently exist in the Ural Saiga concentration zones within the Saratov region. In Kalmykia, conservation efforts should focus on expanding the "Chernye Zemli" Reserve's buffer zone and establishing ecological corridors along Saiga migration routes, either by restoring historical corridors or creating new ones.
- 123 Uzbekistan. Sixty percent of the Saiga range in Uzbekistan is covered by protected areas. There are four protected areas with a total area of 3,575,243 hectares. The last Saiga sightings in two of these areas were recorded in 2012-2014.

7.2 Establish and promote international cooperation in important transboundary Saiga landscapes and where appropriate develop transboundary protected areas.

- 124 During the reporting period transboundary protected areas have not been created. The Russian Federation notes in its National Report that there is a plan to create Troitsky Regional Wildlife Sanctuary (Orenburg province) with an area of 39,280 ha close to Kazakhstan's border. A feasibility study as well as a technical-economic assessment, draft Regulations, and a Decree of the Orenburg province Government were prepared, public hearings were held and approvals were obtained from district authorities

8.0 Population monitoring

- 8.1 Carry out annual population surveys using appropriate methods, including modern non-invasive techniques, in order to obtain time series for all populations that have adequate power to detect whether the MOU goals have been met.

- 125 In Kazakhstan, a national system for annual Saiga population surveys (monitoring) exist. To ensure and inform the protection, reproduction, and utilization of wildlife, the state conducts surveys and wildlife monitoring, which are organized by the Forestry and Wildlife Committee of the Ministry of Ecology and Natural Resources. Saiga monitoring is conducted annually and seasonally by "Okhotzooptom", ACBK, and protected areas staff. More than 75% of the Saiga population is covered by this monitoring. The methods used include aerial and ground vehicle surveys.
- 126 There is no national system for counting Saigas in Mongolia. Despite the absence of a national recording system or database for Saigas, WWF Mongolia has been conducting annual population assessments of the Mongolian Saiga antelope since 1998, providing reports to the government as required. Monitoring is carried out annually and seasonally, covering more than 75% of the population. WWF Mongolia performs annual population assessments and additionally conducts monthly SMART patrols. Ground-based methods are used. During monitoring, population size and age- and sex composition are recorded, but reproductive rates are not. The population assessment employs internationally recognized distance sampling line transect methods across the full range of the Mongolian Saiga distribution, which has been in use since 2010, following the aerial survey conducted in Mongolia.
- 127 In the Russian Federation, there is no nationwide system for counting Saigas. Monitoring of the North-West Pre-Caspian population is conducted annually, covering more than 75% of the population. For the Ural population, monitoring is not done. Monitoring is conducted by protected areas (the "Chernye Zemli" reserve and "Stepnoy" reserve, in collaboration with the Institute of Ecology and Evolution of the Russian Academy of Sciences) using vehicles and observation towers. Russia's Ministry of Natural Resources has developed and approved a method for determining Saiga population numbers using unmanned aerial vehicles (UAVs), as well as a methodology for assessing population size using satellite images. A vehicle-based counting method for the North-West Pre-Caspian Saiga population has also been developed and tested. In protected areas, camera traps are additionally used for monitoring.
- 128 In **Uzbekistan**, there is no nationwide system for counting Saigas. The Ministry of Ecology is responsible for the recording system, and monitoring is carried out by the Institute of Zoology of the Academy of Sciences and the Saiga Conservation Alliance. A system for counting Saigas in transects has been developed for the "Saigachiy" Integrated (Landscape) Reserve, but it has not been officially adopted for annual monitoring. Regular monitoring is not conducted. Monitoring covers 50-75% of the population. For the Ustyurt population, motorcycle surveys along transects are used, as well as camera trap recordings. For the resident Aralkum group, footprint tracks and feces are recorded on selected sites, and camera traps are used to survey the population. During monitoring, population size and age- and sex composition are recorded.

8.2 Carry out research on Saiga movement and migration using appropriate technology (including satellite tracking and remote sensing), with a particular focus on improving understanding of the impacts of infrastructure developments and climate change, and environmental and land use change.

- 129 In **Kazakhstan** ACBK continues tracking Saiga with satellite collars. In 2021-2024 forty-eight collars were deployed across all three Saiga populations. Data is gathered, provided to the Governmental agencies to improve Saiga protection and analysed giving important insights into how Saiga use the landscape. For example, through our telemetry programme, evidence was obtained about the fact that the Ustyurt Saiga population does not cross the Shalkar-Beyneu railway.

Review different monitoring techniques, and adopt 'best practice' methodologies for producing reliable estimates of Saiga populations, including identifying appropriate sample sizes, timing, and frequency of counts to provide reliable baseline population data.

130 **Kazakhstan.** In the framework of the ADCI, ACBK and partners are currently reviewing existing experience and applied methodologies in Africa and elsewhere for counting animals at high abundance and densities to improve the accuracy of Saiga counts in Kazakhstan and particularly of the Ural population.

131 **Russian Federation.** A research project was planned with the objective to develop and test methods to identify and count Saigas on ultrahigh resolution optical satellite images using a combination of deep convolutional neural networks with different types of architecture and study how they use their range.

8.6 Carry out inter-disciplinary research on the health of Saiga and other relevant species (including livestock) to inform mitigation, control, action and timely reporting of the health status of Saiga and disease outbreaks or mass mortality episodes to the appropriate national and international authorities, the public and researchers.

132 **Kazakhstan.** Zhanger Khan University conducts research to study clinical manifestations, physiological parameters and some pathomorphological changes in case of parasitic diseases and helminthic diseases of Saigas in the Ural population and is developing preventive measures. A study and epizootological monitoring is being carried out to identify the most pathogenic helminths parasitizing Saigas and various diseases among livestock. Some clinical and pathomorphologic changes in Saiga helminthic diseases confirmed the need to develop urgent measures to eliminate the parasites detected among farm animals in the West Kazakhstan region. In this regard:

- a) Common helminth species for sheep and Saigas have been identified.
- b) The population immunity of Saigas has been studied (hematological and biochemical studies), as well as the cytopathomorphological aspects of helminthiases (cysticercosis, moniezirosis, and echinococcosis).
- c) An algorithm has been developed for conducting diagnostic and preventive measures for invasive diseases in Saigas under natural biocenoses.
- d) Recommendations have been formulated for comprehensive diagnostics and the implementation of therapeutic and preventive measures for helminthiases in Saigas.
- e) An electronic map has been created showing the epizootic process of helminthiases in Saigas in the West Kazakhstan region.
- f) A patent has been obtained for the "Pathomorphological Diagnostic Method for Cysticercosis in Saigas."

133 **Russian Federation.** In 2019, the Moscow Zoo and the Cherniye Zemli State Reserve jointly developed a program: "Investigation of the epizootic situation and parasitic diseases in the Saiga population of the Northwestern Caspian Sea in the State Reserve "Cherniye Zemli". Since 2020, field visits have been conducted to search for dead animals to collect biological material for research, some of which is sent to laboratories. In addition, nasal flushes were collected from sheep flocks in the border area with the reserve. As a result, about 30% of sheep tested were asymptomatic carriers of *Pasteurella* spp.

8.7 Develop programmes for long-term monitoring of environmental factors and biological sampling from individual animals, including Saiga, livestock and other wildlife (including potential disease vectors).

134 These topics are partially included in the Saiga Conservation Strategy of the **Russian Federation** (approved in 2021).

8.8 Carry out scientific monitoring of Saiga populations, their demographic parameters, and their wider environment, including trends in sex ratio, mortality patterns, reproductive success, age structure, genetics, predators and competitors, in the context of environmental and land use change.

135 **Kazakhstan** has a state funded monitoring system, together with an annual aerial survey, which is frequently conducted by ACBK. During the monitoring they record population numbers, age and sex ratio, as well as reproductive rates. These components are complemented by comprehensive work in the framework of the ADCI including monitoring calving in all populations, the rut, habitat and health.

136 **Russian Federation.** During monitoring, population size, age and sex ratio, and reproductive rates are recorded.

9.0 Captive breeding

9.1 Establish a registry of captive breeding facilities, with details on their purpose, the number of Saigas held in captivity and their origin.

137 In **Kazakhstan** the Committee for Forestry and Wildlife reported that a registry of captive breeding facilities has been established.

9.3 Support existing facilities in the Russian Federation, Kazakhstan, China and Ukraine and encourage them to follow established IUCN and WAZA guidelines and best practice for captive breeding and reintroduction.

138 In Kazakhstan, Saigas are bred in captivity at two locations. The 777-hectare Saiga breeding nursery "ASAR Live" was established in 2021, keeping 1,080 Saigas in semi-wild conditions (in the Ulytau region). Since 2014, the West Kazakhstan Agrarian Technical University named after Zhangir Khan has been conducting scientific research on 466 Saigas using a semi-wild 56-hectare enclosure.

139 The feasibility of breeding Saigas in captivity in Uzbekistan is currently under discussion. Earlier, representatives of Uzbekistan participated in an international workshop on Saiga breeding held in Moscow in 2017.

140 In the Russian Federation, Saiga are kept in captivity at several places. The "Saiga" breeding centre in the Ilymen-Bugrovoy reserve (regional, Astrakhan region) covers 21 hectares and currently requires a population update, as only three individuals are currently living there; it is practically non-functional at present. The Center for Rare Animals of the European Steppes (Public Environmental Organization Association "Living Nature of the Steppe", Rostov region) covers 63 hectares with about 100 Saiga.

141 Outside of the Saiga range, about 300 animals are kept under semi-wild conditions in "Askania Nova" in Ukraine, covering 33,482.7 hectares in total.

9.5 Encourage research into behaviour, feeding, disease and other topics, using the ex situ populations.

- 142 Some research has been conducted recently in the breeding centres in Kazakhstan, mostly on animal health and methods of raising Saiga in captivity (see 9.6).

9.6 Promote research to address challenges in the captive breeding of Saiga antelopes, taking account of existing experiences and advice [see 9.5], and develop best practices guidance for Saiga husbandry, management and transport.

- 143 Some research is conducted in the breeding centres in Kazakhstan, which also resulted in one publication (Kushaliyev et al., 2024). But no best practice guidance exists for Saiga husbandry.

9.7 Assess the feasibility of establishing captive breeding and reintroduction facilities in Mongolia, Uzbekistan or other parts of the present or former Saiga range.

- 144 Two new captive breeding facilities have been created in Kazakhstan, one near Uralsk named “Akbroken” run by the West-Kazakhstan University and the second one in Central Kazakhstan (run by the company “Azar Live”), but they are not used for reintroduction.

10.0 Health and disease

10.8 Carry out general health research on Saiga, including regular monitoring of mortality such as during field missions at calving sites.

- 145 In Kazakhstan this is partly implemented by ACBK, Okhotzoooprom and protected area rangers in the context of annual Saiga monitoring.

Population-specific measures

11.0 North-West Pre-Caspian region population (Russian Federation)

11.1 Improve the effectiveness of law enforcement and anti-poaching activities in the Saiga range, using modern methods.

- 146 Anti-poaching is organized and implemented by regional Ministries, departments and directorates responsible for biodiversity conservation in their regions, federal and regional protected areas and the Ministry of Internal Affairs. In protected areas Saiga conservation and anti-poaching activities are carried out on a daily basis using vehicles, as well as observation from towers and through interviews with the local people. Outside protected areas, rangers conduct raids at least once a week, and constantly during the rutting and calving periods. As a result, no cases of poaching have been recorded in the territory of the North-West Pre-Caspian region population since 2019.

11.2 Ensure research on the morphological and genetic diversity of the species to identify individuals, herds, and populations of Saigas, impacts of climate change on Saigas and their habitats, and effects of predators and diseases on Saigas.

- 147 According to the national report of the Russian Federation, the Institute for Problems of Ecology and Evolution of the Russian Academy of Sciences is responsible for conducting scientific research to assess the status of Saiga populations. Their work encompasses a wide range of activities, including monitoring Saiga populations and tagging animals with transmitters to study their spatial movements. They also investigate the impact of wolves on Saigas in the North-West Pre-Caspian region, assess habitat

conditions within the Saiga range using remote sensing and on-site surveys, and employ modern modeling techniques to evaluate habitat suitability, fragmentation levels, and genetic diversity. Additionally, they conduct genetic studies to assess population diversity and sustainability.

- 148 According to the study "The Modern State of the European Saiga Population (Saiga tatarica tatarica): mtDNA, DRB3 MHC Gene, and Microsatellite Diversity," no critically low level of genetic diversity has been identified in this population.
- 149 The Ministry of Natural Resources of Kalmykia reports that the wolf population in Kalmykia is very high, estimated at around 700 to 1,200 individuals, causing damage to both livestock and Saigas. However, a study on the population structure of wolves in the Northwest Caspian and their impact on Saigas suggests that the actual number of wolves in this region is no more than 70 individuals, with 54 identified across all protected areas.
- 150 Analysis of wolf excrement indicates that Saiga antelope constitute between 31% and 69% of the wolf diet, depending on the pack's territory, with an average of approximately 50%. Efforts to cull wolves have likely contributed to increased hybridization between wolves and stray dogs, leading to a rise in the number of wolf-dog hybrids. These hybrids are believed to cause significantly more damage to steppe ecosystems than wolves.

11.3 Conduct regular, scientifically robust monitoring and assessments of Saiga population size and distribution, using non-invasive methods.

- 151 Has been implemented during the reporting period. See 8.1 and 8.3 for details.

11.4 Carry out systematic work for the engagement of local people with Saiga conservation through participatory monitoring, education, awareness raising, and sustainable livelihoods, including the development of ecological tourism, not causing harm to Saiga.

- 152 Education and awareness raising work is described in 5.3, 5.4. No information about the development of ecological tourism is available.

11.6 Ensure the development of a network of protected areas of federal and regional importance and activities to optimise nature use in the Saiga range to ensure protection of key Saiga habitats in the Russian Federation.

- 153 Currently the protected areas focused on Saiga conservation cover 771,500 ha, which is 77% of the existing range. Gaps in the protected areas network for Saiga have been identified. The work to create new ones and extend existing ones is complete.

12.0 Ural population

12.1 Improve anti-poaching activities through close cooperation between wildlife protection services and other law enforcement agencies, involving local people.

- 154 In the Republic of Kazakhstan, an annual large-scale campaign called "Saiga" is organized to combat Saiga poaching and illegal trade. The campaign includes:
 - a) Establishing a coordination headquarters to oversee collaboration between law enforcement and conservation agencies, including the Ministry of Ecology, the Ministry of Internal Affairs, and the Committee for National Security.
 - b) Deploying joint mobile units to identify and apprehend Saiga horn buyers.

- c) Monitoring social media and other media platforms to detect the buying and selling of Saiga horn derivatives.
- d) Intensifying operational search efforts to prevent the illegal import and export of Saiga derivatives at border crossings and in border areas.

12.2 Carry out research into the factors predisposing the population to mass mortality from disease including transmissible diseases from livestock, and implement mitigating measures based on the findings.

155 The Kazakh Research Veterinary Institute conducted a literature review and research in 2023-2024. This research showed that there are currently no up-to-date lists detailing all diseases to which Saigas may be susceptible. More information is provided in 8.6.

12.3 Implement measures to eliminate the negative impact of international border barriers on migrating Saiga.

156 During the reporting period no actions have been taken to eliminate the negative impact of international border barriers on migrating Saigas. Some research activities are described in 6.1.

12.4 Strengthen public awareness and engagement activities, including particularly with respect to conservation value of Saiga and disease control.

157 No such specific actions have been implemented for the Ural Saiga population, only general actions described in 5.3, 5.4, 5.6.

12.5 Strengthen cooperation between Russia and Kazakhstan for management of this transboundary population in the framework of existing and planned agreements

158 Kazakhstan and the Russian Federation are working collaboratively in the framework of the “Agreement between the Ministry of Natural Resources and Ecology of the Russian Federation and the Ministry of Ecology and Natural Resources of the Republic of Kazakhstan on the protection, reproduction and use of transboundary Saiga populations (Saiga tatarica tatarica).”

12.6 Create a holistic monitoring programme to support Saiga management decisions related to sustainable Saiga use, including the contribution to the continued development of population models, collecting data on Saiga distribution, population structure and threats, taking into account the trans-boundary nature of the population.

159 For details on annual monitoring and surveys see section 8.1

12.7 Develop a human-wildlife conflict mitigation scheme to make peaceful cohabitation of people with their livestock and Saiga possible

160 See 3.10

13.0 Ustyurt population

13.1 Strengthen anti-poaching activity in Kazakhstan and Uzbekistan, including, where possible, the involvement of voluntary rangers from local communities and community-based NGOs, national and transboundary cooperation between relevant agencies such as inspectors, border guards, customs officers and police.

161 Anti-poaching work on the Ustyurt plateau in Kazakhstan is conducted by Okhotzooptom rangers. ACBK established an Ustyurt monitoring team in 2017 to conduct regular monitoring and support state rangers by having a regular presence on the territory and organizing joint raids with the territorial inspection or Okhotzooptom.

162 Anti-poaching work in Uzbekistan has been strengthened by the creation of new protected areas with additional rangers employed, receiving the relevant training.

13.3 Support the recently established Integrated Saigachy (Landscape) Reserve, National nature park "Southern Ustyurt" and other protected areas in Ustyurt, consider the possibility to create a protected area in Kazakhstan in the north and south Ustiurt and continue to consider expanding the protected area network, respecting ecological connectivity and ensuring support and engagement of local people.

163 Support has been provided to the newly established Saigachy (Landscape) Reserve and the National Nature Park "Southern Ustyurt" through staff training and the implementation of the SMART monitoring system in Saigachy Reserve. Additionally, a transect-based survey system has been developed for the Saigachy Integrated (Landscape) Reserve, though it has yet to be officially adopted for annual monitoring.

164 In Kazakhstan, a feasibility study for the expansion of the Ustyurt State Nature Reserve has been completed and approved. Currently, ACBK is preparing a technical-economic assessment, as the next step to implement the expansion.

13.4 Based on 6.1 and 6.2, require developers to carry out mitigation measures to minimise the impact of barriers on movement on the population, particularly border fences at the Kazakhstan-Uzbek border, the Shalkar-Beyneu railway section, the A380 Kungrad-Beyneu road section, as well as disturbance from infrastructure and other industrial development activities. Existing linear infrastructure, such as railways and roads, should be adapted to allow Saiga to cross.

165 No information provided on whether developers are required to carry out such activities. See 6.1 for examples of implemented mitigation measures.

13.5 Continue research on the seasonal distribution and numbers of Saiga and the status of their habitat, with a particular emphasis on the role of infrastructure and border fencing in constraining movement, and on the locations of, abundance, and threats to resident populations.

166 Regular monitoring and data gathering is conducted by ACBK and Okhotzooptom rangers. ACBK installed 4 satellite collars in 2023 in the Ustyurt Saiga range to obtain more data about Saiga movements and the influence of linear infrastructure on Saiga migration.

13.6 Encourage local communities and civil society organizations to support conservation activities on the Ustiurt Plateau, ensuring that local people have the opportunity to participate in, and to obtain benefits from conservation.

167 See 4.1.

13.7 Develop and expand education and awareness raising, as well as community engagement and conservation-related income-generating enterprises.

168 All awareness raising and educational activities are described in detail in section 5.

13.8 Restore the ecological integrity of Ustyurt as a transboundary landscape by establishing transboundary ecological corridors and protected areas

169 Barriers to migratory species remain in place and have not been effectively mitigated. However, the signing of the Memorandum for Cooperation on the Conservation of Wildlife on the Ustyurt Plateau (Ustyurt Memorandum) at the Fourteenth Meeting of the Conference of the Parties to CMS, along with the planned development of a Roadmap for its implementation in March 2025, represent significant steps toward addressing this issue.

13.9 Strengthen the implementation of the existing bilateral and/or trilateral cooperation agreements between Kazakhstan, Uzbekistan and Turkmenistan to ensure coordinated action to implement the agreements.

170 For more information on the Ustyurt Memorandum please see UNEP/CMS/Saiga/MOS5/Doc.2

13.10 Include the Ustyurt population in a holistic monitoring programme in order to gain detailed data on the status of the population based on highest scientific standards, which allow conclusions for its conservation and future management.

171 See 8.1 on annual population surveys.

14.0 Betpak-Dala population

14.1 Strengthen anti-poaching efforts, targeting areas where Saiga Antelopes are particularly vulnerable, through close cooperation of wildlife protection services and other law enforcement agencies, and involving local communities, where appropriate.

172 Through close cooperation between Okhotzooptom, territorial inspections, protected areas rangers and hunting areas rangers, anti-poaching efforts have been strengthened. See 12.1 and 2.0.

14.2 Ensure that Saiga antelope mitigation measures are taken when developing transport and other linear infrastructure in accordance with the principles of the mitigation hierarchy.

173 As part of the modernization of the Zhezkazgan-Karaganda road section, the World Bank contracted ACBK's specialists to assess the impact of the road on biodiversity and suggest mitigation measures, especially for Saiga. Fieldwork was finished in 2022-2023 and the final report was provided to the World Bank for further consideration and action.

14.3 Continue and extend the monitoring of the health status of the population, especially at calving time.

174 Basic monitoring, including calving success, is conducted annually by ACBK, protected area and Okhotzooptom rangers. For details see 8.1 Specific monitoring of the health status of the population has not been conducted.

14.6 Conduct public engagement activities, awareness-raising and community involvement in Saiga conservation

175 See 5.3, 5.4, 5.6, no specific activities in the Betpak Dala population.

14.7 Support effective management of protected areas and develop ecological corridors to ensure that the protected area network is relevant to the Saiga's current and particularly its future needs, including in the light of climate change, agricultural and infrastructural development.

176 The Government of Kazakhstan financially supports protected areas established for Saiga protection and conservation. ACBK has contributed to the monitoring and protection of part of the existing ecological corridor "Irgiz-Torgay-Zhylanshyk" by managing "Alty Sai" ecological park (343,500 ha). ACBK also conducts training for protected area staff including rangers in the Betpak-Dala population range.

14.8 Implement activities under the agreement between the Ministry of Ecology and Natural Resources of the Russian Federation and the Ministry of Ecology, Geology and Natural Resources of the Republic of Kazakhstan on the protection, reproduction and use of transboundary Saiga populations (*Saiga tatarica tatarica*).

177 Joint work plans were developed and approved by Kazakhstan and Russian Federation in the frame of this Agreement. Information about Saiga migration, calving and rutting has been shared between inspectors from the two countries. Joint commission has been created in 2024 to conduct research, gather more information about Saiga migration and prepare recommendations to change the border fence or remove it in some key places.

14.9 Develop and implement a holistic monitoring programme for the Betpak-Dala population to support Saiga management decisions related to future sustainable Saiga use, including the contribution to the continued development of population models, collecting data on Saiga distribution, population structure and threats.

178 See 8.1 for details on annual population surveys.

15.0 Mongolia population

15.1 Enhance the protected area network by identifying new sites or upgrading existing sites, where appropriate.

179 WWF Mongolia lobbied for and subsequently supported two local protected areas in the Khyargas lake population of Saiga (also called Zavkhan population), which resides in the Zavkhan soum of Uvs province and Durgun soum of Khovd province. To solidify this success and ensure habitat quality of the Khyargas lake population, WWF Mongolia has developed the justification for the creation of a new Nature Reserve. In addition, WWF Mongolia identified 34 core Saiga habitats of 12,480 sq.km in total (30.7% of the current Mongolian Saiga range) and 68 least cost-paths (ecological corridors) connecting core habitats across the entire Saiga range.

15.2 Strengthen local engagement in Saiga conservation and reduce conflict through livelihood enhancement and public awareness activities, including community rangers, educational initiatives and ecotourism.

180 Described in detail in 4.4, 4.5, 5.3, 5.4

15.4 Continue research into the seasonal Saiga distribution, with updated information on range, movement, reproduction, genetics and mortality, in order to inform conservation planning, with a particular emphasis on grazing overlap, competition, Saiga health and disease transmission between Saiga and livestock.

181 Described in detail in section 8.0

15.5 Continue to apply and improve the current standardised, robust approaches to population monitoring, in order to monitor population trends.

182 Described in detail in section 8.0.

15.6 Carry out genetic research on Mongolian Saiga using the latest technology, in order to ascertain its phylogenetic relationship to other Saiga populations.

183 Described in detail in 1.5

15.8 Strengthen the capacity of law enforcement agencies to combat the illegal trade in Saiga derivatives.

184 Described in detail in 2.5

15.9 Strengthen protection, including adequate funding for anti-poaching patrols and effective protected area management.

185 The Government of Mongolia committed to adopt SMART for the State Protected Areas Network of 120 State Protected Areas. WWF Mongolia supported SMART training for 123 rangers from 9 Protected Area Administrations. To ensure successful adoption of SMART by those protected areas, WWF Mongolia plans to provide technical support over the coming 2 years.

15.11 Continue research into emerging threats including possible impacts of infrastructure, mining, climate change and disease, in order to inform conservation planning and mitigation.

186 Please see sections 6.0, 8.0 and 10.0

5. Conclusion: successes, challenges and main conservation needs

Successes

187 **Population recovery:** One of the most significant successes in Saiga conservation has been the substantial increase in population numbers in Kazakhstan. From 2021 to 2024, the Ural and Betpak-Dala populations of Saiga more than doubled, indicating the effectiveness of country-wide conservation measures.'

188 **Combatting poaching:** Kazakhstan, Russia, Mongolia, and Uzbekistan have implemented substantial measures to combat poaching. In Mongolia, thanks to the introduction of the SMART patrolling system since 2017, there have been no recorded instances of poaching. In Kazakhstan, state rangers actively enforce laws and conduct

annual campaigns to prevent Saiga poaching, which has led to an improved identification and conviction of poachers.

- 189 **International projects and cooperation:** Significant achievements include active international cooperation to tackle illegal trade in Saiga products. For example, the WCS project in China investigates supply chains for Saiga horns, while Malaysia has developed a project for managing stockpiles of horns in Traditional Chinese Medicine (TCM) institutions. These initiatives help both to identify illegal shipments and to reduce demand.
- 190 **Awareness raising:** In all Saiga Range States public awareness campaigns, educational programs for children, and events like "Saiga Day" have been conducted with numerous participants. These efforts help to change attitudes towards conservation and reduce poaching. The Saiga Resource Center and Saiga News remained a widely used resource for conservationists.
- 191 **Creation of protected areas:** New protected areas have been established in the Saiga range in Kazakhstan, Uzbekistan, and Mongolia, covering key habitats such as calving and rutting areas. These measures significantly contribute to the conservation of the respective populations.

Challenges

- 192 **High demand for saiga horns of illegal origin:** The ongoing high demand for Saiga horns in Southeast Asian countries, particularly in Traditional Chinese Medicine, remains a major issue. Intensive poaching continues due to the high value of horns on the black market. Seizures of illegally traded Saiga horn have reached extremely high levels that have not been seen before.
- 193 **Habitat fragmentation and migration barriers:** Infrastructure developments, such as railroads and fences, severely hinder the natural migration of Saiga Antelope, especially along the borders of Kazakhstan, Russia, and Uzbekistan. Some infrastructure projects, like railways, do not include provisions for wildlife corridors, which restricts Saiga movements and threatens their survival.
- 194 **Conflicts with farmers:** In Western Kazakhstan, the increase in Saiga numbers has led to a rising competition for resources like pastures and water between livestock and Saiga. This results in conflicts between local people and wildlife agencies, rangers and NGOs, particularly in arid regions. The problem is exacerbated by the growing number of domestic livestock.
- 195 **Limited research on socio-economic factors:** There is limited research on the socio-economic reasons behind local residents' involvement in poaching and the search for solutions that could reduce their reliance on illegal trade. Without understanding the socio-economic factors influencing poaching, it is difficult to develop long-term prevention strategies.
- 196 **Disease risks:** Diseases including those which are transmitted from domestic livestock to wild Saiga populations continue to threaten the species across its range. This issue is not sufficiently addressed due to limited funding. Preventing such diseases requires additional monitoring and control measures.

Main conservation needs:

- 197 **Equipment and training for rangers:** All Range States have indicated that a continuous and significant flow of funding is needed to keep up the currently efficient work of state rangers. This is not only needed to pay their salaries, but to replace damaged or outdated equipment, which they need to fulfil their duties properly. Capacity-building and training is also needed.

- 198 **Strengthening border controls and combating illegal trade:** There is a need to improve coordination among Range States and consumer countries to prevent illegal trade in Saiga products. Enhancing border controls, training customs and law enforcement personnel, and increasing the number of rangers can significantly improve the situation. The implementation of CITES regulations is essential for addressing these issues. Establishing robust monitoring and reporting systems to track illegal trade in Saiga products is vital. Countries should ensure regular and timely reporting to CITES about the status of Saiga populations, illegal trade incidents, and enforcement actions taken. This transparency can enhance accountability and facilitate coordinated efforts among countries. A stockpile management system is urgently needed in Range States and all countries trading in stockpiles.

- 199 **Sustainable use in Kazakhstan:** Given the large population sizes in Kazakhstan, resuming use of Saiga is feasible at least for some populations, as stated in the report [“The Sustainable Use of Saiga Antelope: Perspectives and Prospects”](#). A system of sustainable use should be developed based on the recommendations of the abovementioned report, building on the recommendations of the report [“Potential for Community-based Wildlife Management in Central Asia”](#) and [the Conservation and Management Strategy for Saiga in Kazakhstan](#).

- 200 In general, for sustainable use of Saiga it is important to develop a participatory system, which includes all relevant stakeholders, including local communities, in decision making processes and ensures that resulting benefits are shared equitably, to mitigate existing conflicts and to enable a peaceful coexistence of people and Saiga.

- 201 **Restoration of migration corridors and habitat:** To ensure the long-term survival of Saiga, it is essential to restore their migration routes. Removing existing barriers such as fences and railways, or mitigating their barrier effect and creating safe crossings for animals will help facilitate the movement of Saiga within their range.

- 202 **Creating sustainable livelihoods for local communities:** Providing alternative income sources for local residents, such as eco-tourism, sustainable agricultural programs, and projects focused on the sustainable use of natural resources, can help reduce pressure on Saiga habitat and poaching.

- 203 **Increased funding for research and monitoring:** Intense monitoring and the introduction of new technologies, such as the use of drones, GPS trackers, and satellite data, are crucial for understanding Saiga population dynamics and their migrations as well as habitat requirements. Research on the carrying capacity of population ranges should be initiated and the research on diseases needs to be intensified to be able to predict and adequately react to disease outbreaks.

- 204 **Building transparent governance frameworks:** Establishing transparent governance frameworks can significantly reduce corruption risk, enhance understanding of and support for conservation and management measures.

- 205 Effective implementation of conservation measures requires close cooperation between governments, research institutions, and international organizations, facilitated by Convention Secretariats, such as CMS and CITES. The success of Saiga conservation relies on a comprehensive approach that includes good governance based on scientific research, continuous law enforcement measures, and sustainable livelihoods for local communities.

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7. Annex: Information and implementation gaps

A. Information gaps

No information was available to the authors on the implementation of the following Activities from the Saiga MTIWP 2021-2025:

1.1 Encourage all potential partner and cooperating organizations to support the CMS MOU by contributing to the implementation of the Medium-Term International Work Programme.

1.4 Encourage all countries with an interest in Saiga conservation, including trading, consumer and captive-population holding countries to engage with and support the CMS MOU.

1.13 Encourage Range States to coordinate their research and monitoring efforts in order to maximize the synergies between them, where appropriate using standardized, comparable, internationally recognized methods.

2.1 Develop and, if necessary, update national anti-poaching strategies, with a focus at the population level in order to maximize effectiveness of patrol deployment and intelligence-gathering.

2.6 Improve legal protection of informants who provide information about poaching incidents.

3.3 Encourage Range States and Saiga trading and consumer countries to comply with CITES decisions and recommendations relevant to Saiga antelopes.

3.5 Encourage all Range States that are Parties to CITES to achieve a Category 1 rating for their CITES implementing legislation.

4.3 Recognize and encourage responsible behaviour by external stakeholders in the Saiga range, including border guards, industry employees and managers in order to prevent negative impacts on the Saiga population, either directly or through relationships with local communities.

5.2 Develop and implement awareness-raising campaigns for investors, companies and governments in Range States and elsewhere, whose activities, or the activities of whose employees, could negatively impact on Saiga conservation.

 5.5 Develop and implement awareness raising and behaviour change campaigns to reduce demand for Saiga products in consumer countries.

8.4 Carry out training and build capacity for biological sampling, transportation, storage and clinical diagnostics for researchers and government staff at all levels.

8.5 Develop and expand programmes of monitoring of Saiga in collaboration with local people.

 8.9 Provide training in standard monitoring techniques as appropriate and disseminate methods through publications and the Saiga Resource Centre.

8.10 Encourage use of comparable techniques and reporting standards in all Range States, data and report sharing where possible, and joint analysis in the case of transboundary populations.

9.2 Promote the exchange of expertise in captive breeding, including study tours between captive breeding centres.

9.4 Take into account the results of the international workshop on captive breeding for Saiga conservation, held in Moscow in 2017.

10.1 Create national wildlife disease surveillance schemes for Saiga antelopes, which include passive monitoring and standard operating procedures for disease outbreaks, and encourage governments to adopt these for other wildlife species as well.

10.2 Promote specific interventions to reduce risk of exposure and encourage elimination of Peste des Petits Ruminants virus from livestock populations sharing Saiga habitat and in Saiga regions through comprehensive/systematic livestock vaccination (through the global PPR eradication programme coordinated by FAO / OIE and national veterinary authorities).

10.5 Raise awareness of health and Saiga-relevant disease in Saiga, other wildlife and livestock among stakeholders throughout the Saiga range, including veterinarians, government agencies, rangers, local communities and researchers.

10.6 Encourage cooperation and communication transparency among technical health agencies on disease research results in free-ranging and captive Saiga.

10.7 Monitor and control the disease risk to Saiga associated with cross-border movement of livestock, their products and derivatives.

11.5 Ensure the effective cooperation of state authorities and protected area managers to support the effective functioning of federal and regional protected areas located in the Saiga range.

11.7 Ensure the implementation of the strategy for Saiga conservation in the Russian Federation and the roadmap (action plan) for Saiga conservation and restoration in the Russian Federation.

11.8 Ensure the effective work of the Saiga conservation and restoration expert section of the working group on conservation and restoration of certain rare and endangered wildlife species in the Russian Federation under the Ministry of Natural Resources and Ecology of the Russian Federation.

11.9 Improve the institutional capacity and effectiveness of the national and regional authorities responsible for Saiga management, and strengthen their links with the CMS contact point, CITES Management Authority and other administrative units of the Russian Federation and internationally.

15.3 Disseminate appropriate and clear information among local communities on wildlife diseases (the risk of spillover from livestock to Saiga antelope) and the guidelines to report diseases to animal health authorities.

15.7 Encourage animal health authorities to vaccinate livestock in the Saiga range against PPR to control the risk of transmission to susceptible wildlife.

B. Implementation gaps

No measures were taken during the reporting period to implement the MTIWP activities listed below

3.9 Encourage cooperation between in-situ conservationists and the Asian medicine industry for promotion of Saiga conservation, restoration and sustainable use, including information sharing and financial support.

10.3 Encourage further collaboration on haemorrhagic septicaemia research between governments and researchers across Range States and with international institutions. and 10.4 **Create an international working group on diseases affecting or threatening Saiga across its range.**

11.10 Support participation of and financial contributions **from business organisations** and NGOs in Saiga conservation, research, and monitoring activities as well as in engaging local communities in Saiga conservation.

13.2 Make special efforts to build cooperation at the operational level between (currently) Kazakhstan and Uzbekistan to ensure effective anti-poaching and conservation actions for this transboundary landscape.

14.4 Implement measures to eliminate the negative impact of international border barriers on migrating Saigas.

14.5 Develop and implement a long-term research programme on Saiga diseases including national and international expertise, and communicate results to local people and rangers as well as to the general public nationally and internationally.

15.10 Establish a facility to support reintroduction into historical parts of the range and ensure that the genetic diversity of the population is preserved, using best practice under IUCN guidelines.